



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

COURSE REPORT FOR FIRST CYCLE COURSES IN POLITICAL SCIENCE

The aim of the course report is to demonstrate responsiveness towards the students' views, guarantee the quality of the course, and stimulate subject related and pedagogical development. The report should have a forward-looking focus and be based on the course coordinator's own reflections and input received from students (individually or in groups), teaching staff, education administrators, and the study counsellor, as well as the course evaluation.

Course name: Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA) Course code: SK1136 Semester: Spring Semester 2025		Course coordinator (name and e-mail address): Lisbeth Aggestam lisbeth.aggestam@gu.se
Brief description of course content and structure	The course is part of the International Politics track in the second year of the Political Science Program. It was offered for the second time on this program and is also taught to Erasmus and free-standing students. The course introduces students to Foreign Policy Analysis (FPA) as a distinct subfield of International Politics, providing theoretical and conceptual tools to explain foreign policy. Students are expected to learn to apply different FPA theories and models of foreign policy decision-making to empirical cases and to describe the foreign policy-making process and implementation. Teaching includes lectures and seminars with written and oral components.	
Completion rate and grades	Out of 36 registered students, 30 students had completed the course by August 2025. 16 students received a High Pass, and 14 students received a Pass.	
General and specific impressions of the course	The course structure is well-established and works well with a combination of teaching methods, including interactive lectures and seminars that include group presentations by students.	
Students' general impressions of the course	The response rate on the course evaluation was low with only 7 out of 36 registered students responding, which raise questions how representative they are. 5 out of 7 students rated the course 'rather good to very good' (71,4%).	

Students' impressions of specific elements of the course	<i>Lectures</i> were generally well received and all students rated teachers 'rather to very good' (100%). They commented that teachers were 'knowledgeable and helpful'. In terms of the contents of the lectures, some students found FPA theories challenging to grasp and apply, particularly in their final research paper. Generally, students would like more empirical elaboration of the theories in relation to world events and foreign policy issues. The format of <i>student-led seminars</i> with oral presentation and discussion is appreciated by students with 6 out of 7 students rating them 'rather to very good'. Apart from the intellectual learning experience, these seminars are intended to practice generic skills of group teamwork and presentation. Some students called for more detailed seminar instructions although these were revised in extensively this semester and outlined clearly in the introductory lecture as well as on Canvas. Students are satisfied (71,4% rather to very good) with the <i>course literature</i>, particularly the FPA textbook by Oppermann and Brummer (2024) but some students raised issues that it can be hard to access given that it is not provided as an e-book. Although it is communicated at the start of the course that students are expected to purchase the core textbook, there seems to be an assumption that all the literature should be available online for free. In terms of <i>workload</i>, 85,7% of students consider it OK which can be interpreted as an overall good balance of work for students on the course.
Impressions of students' and teachers' views on the administration of the course, incl. Canvas	The course organization and administration ran smoothly and 7 out of 8 students think it 'rather to very good'. One student would like to see the instructions for the final assignment published at the start of the course although there is a pedagogical reason for why it is published in the latter half of the course.
Ideas of potential changes for the next round	Based on the student evaluation and feedback, the following changes will be made next time the course is running: • Explain and elaborate more in the first introductory lecture the purpose of theory and introducing the FPA 'tool-kit' that forms the backbone of this course. • Integrate more empirical case studies in the lectures. • Consider publishing the instructions for the final research paper earlier.
Ideas of long-term and/or more comprehensive changes	The fast-moving developments and impact of AI on teaching require continuous reflection on forms of assessment and activities. • Replace the final research paper with a written exam or alternatively combining it with an oral examination.

	Maintain compulsory seminars with group presentations but remove individual seminar papers.														
Other comments	From the course evaluation question: "Overall, how do you assess the course?" <table><tr><td></td><td>VT25</td><td>HT25</td><td>VT26</td><td>HT26</td><td>VT27</td><td>HT27</td></tr><tr><td>Means</td><td>2,1</td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td><td></td></tr></table> Note: Five-point scale on which 1 corresponds to very good and 5 to very bad.		VT25	HT25	VT26	HT26	VT27	HT27	Means	2,1					
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